

Changes in Religious Affiliation in Leicester (2011–2021)

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Based on UK Census data (ONS)

1. Introduction

This report examines changes in religious affiliation in Leicester between 2011 and 2021. Using data from the UK Census, the analysis identifies major trends in both main world religions and smaller religious groups. The aim is to understand how Leicester's religious composition has evolved over a decade and what these changes may imply for local communities and public policy.

2. Data and Methodology

Data come from the 2011 and 2021 Censuses (Office for National Statistics).

The analysis covers:

- total population,
- main world religions,
- smaller (minor) religious groups,
- people with no religion,
- people who did not state their religion.

Percentages were calculated based on the total usual resident population in Leicester. Changes are presented as percentage point differences between 2011 and 2021.

Limitations:

- The census religion question is voluntary.
- Some minor religions have very small counts, which may affect reliability.
- Data for 2011 and 2021 are not perfectly comparable due to changes in question wording and response options.

3. General Trends

Category	2011	2021	Change
Main religions	71.06%	70.92%	slight decrease
No religion	22.82%	22.96%	stable
Religion not stated	5.56%	5.56%	stable
Other religions	0.56%	0.56%	stable

Key finding:

The share of people belonging to one of the six main world religions decreased very slightly, while other categories remained stable.

4. Main Religions

Religion	2011 (%)	2021 (%)	Change (p.p.)
Christian	32.40%	24.73%	-7.67
Buddhist	0.37%	0.32%	-0.05
Hindu	15.19%	17.86%	2.67
Jewish	0.09%	0.09%	0
Muslim	18.63%	23.45%	4.82
Sikh	4.38%	4.46%	0.08

Key findings:

- Christianity declined significantly (by almost 8 percentage points).
- Hinduism and Islam grew considerably.
- Other main religions remained relatively stable.

5. Minor Religions

The largest minor religious groups in Leicester (by number of adherents):

Religion	2011	2021	Change
Jain	496	513	slight increase
Pagan	320	307	slight decrease
Ravidassia	162	142	slight decrease
Spiritual	64	149	133%
Spiritualist	169	107	decrease

Key findings:

- The number of people identifying as *Spiritual* more than doubled.
- Other minor religions such as Jain, Pagan, Ravidassia, and Spiritualist showed small declines or remained stable.

6. Discussion

Leicester's religious landscape changed noticeably between 2011 and 2021. The most striking trend is the decline in Christianity and the growth of Hinduism and Islam.

These changes likely reflect:

- migration patterns,
- demographic trends (age structure, birth rates),
- changing self-identification, especially among younger generations.

The rise in the number of people identifying as *Spiritual* (not tied to a traditional religion) is also noteworthy and may indicate broader shifts in how people understand religious or spiritual belonging.

7. Conclusion

Between 2011 and 2021, Leicester became more religiously diverse. Christianity lost ground, while Hinduism, Islam, and smaller spiritual groups gained followers. These findings are relevant for policymakers, community organisations, and researchers interested in social cohesion, public services, and cultural integration in Leicester.

8. References

- Office for National Statistics (ONS). Census 2011 and 2021 data on religion (Leicester).
- Nomis (www.nomisweb.co.uk) – Census data tables.